you are the king of the world but with the attitude that you don't care who is."

Bachchan, for his part, is perhaps too sensitive to have an attitude like Gangaram's. He cares about what people say—even if it is criticism of his work or some disparaging comment on his social media feed. "Every opinion matters," he says. "Even if one person says negative [things], I want to know why and if I can do something to change their mind or improve myself."

Though we will only know how audiences respond to Bachchan's fourth straight direct-to-digital release on April 7, the actor himself, an "eternal pessimist", believes that *Dasvi* is a "good film", the kind to leave you "with something to think about". While it's not in Bachchan's nature to scream about his work from the rooftops, he is learning to give himself some credit. "I don't want to shy away anymore from saying 'Hey, you know what? I worked really hard and I am happy with the film.' It is important to be humble, but maybe one can acknowledge the good things as well." ■

–Suhani Singh



After appearing as the second lead in a string of films, Bachchan took a two-year sabbatical to recoup. Fortunately, he returned with an inspired performance in *Manmarziyan*. By casting him as the ever-understanding Robbie Bhatia, director Anurag Kashyap endeared Bachchan to us all over again.

OTT/ FILM

NATURAL BORN STORYTELLER

Go Goa Gone and Lootcase *actor* **Kunal Kemmu** *talks to us about the latest season of his ZEE5 show* Abhay, *bringing Ram Jethmalani's story to screen and his abiding interest in writing and direction*



What was it like to return as the bad-tempered but brilliant investigating officer, Abhay Pratap Singh, for a third season?
I always wanted to do something in the web space and the fact that *Abhay* is now in its third season is a testament to its success. That it's a detective show which has the protagonist's name as the title—like Karamchand or Byomkesh Bakshi—is so cool. Abhay has become my second skin. I slip into character as soon as I wear his shoes and *kada* (bracelet).

Q. Last year, you spoke about a Ram Jethmalani biopic that you and your wife, Soha Ali Khan, wanted to produce. What's happening with that? Are you getting into production?
We are still going to tell that story, but in a different form and format. That's also because it's a huge responsibility and we want to do justice to his story. We are very excited about it, even if it is taking a long time. For now, our plans to get into production are limited to this subject.

Q. There have been rumours that you have written a film and that you will be directing it. When did you discover your interest in writing and directing?
I can't comment on the rumours, but, yes, I've always been interested. I started acting when I was six and have practically grown up on film sets. My grandfather was a playwright and my dad is from NSD (National School of Drama), so I've always loved storytelling. Whether I was on a film set or on stage, I was interested in the workings of other departments, especially writing and direction. I got my first formal opportunity as a dialogue writer on *Go Goa Gone*. Since then, I have been writing quite regularly.

Q. Writing requires a different kind of discipline. Is that something that comes to you easily?
When it comes to the writing process, I know that there are different schools of thought. There are writers who wake up early in the morning and dedicate a certain amount of time to write. They have to write in that time. I am not a trained writer and my learning was driven by passion. So, I have only written when I have had a brainwave. There are times when I write non-stop for five days and then I don't write for the next few months. ■

–with Karishma Upadhyay



"Abhay [the character] has become my second skin. I slip into character as soon as I wear his shoes and kada"